Foreword

When I first started out as a broadcaster, I was told, ‘Always remember you have to tell a story.’ I have kept that adage in mind. Ever since I was a child, I have been a devotee of the railways. It has been almost eighty years now since my earliest encounters with the Indian Railways, travelling to Darjeeling where I went to school, or to Puri for the winter holidays. So I have always sought opportunities to tell railway tales in my broadcasts, films and books.

In the TV film *From Karachi to the Khyber* , I have told the story of workers lowered from cliff tops on platforms having to find their own footholds so that they could blast a route with explosives through the mountainous Bolan Pass to take the railway to the Pakistani city of Quetta. In the same film, there is the story of an engineer who persuaded hostile Pathan tribesmen to allow him to build the line through the Khyber Pass by telling them the trains would go so slowly they could easily be looted. In another film, *An Indian Summer of Steam* , there is a maharaja who remembered having his own royal train, and a steam engine driver who burst into tears when his engine broke down .

I have told tales, too, of my encounters with passengers. There was the passenger on the Khyber Mail who I found reading my book *No Full Stops in India* . He told me I had no reason to be pleased about this, because he was reading a pirated copy, and went on to say, ‘Now write *No Punctuation Marks in Pakistan* .’ Another time, while making a radio programme about the Mumbai–Howrah Mail running on the Raj’s Imperial Mail route via Allahabad, I asked a passenger whether I could interview her. She replied, ‘By all means, but you should really interview my husband. He is a comedian who specializes in imitating the different ways passengers snore